

Tasin Academy

Opposite to Alekanda Govt College, Barishal

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An old man with steel-rimmed spectacles and very dusty clothes sat by the side of the road. There was a pontoon bridge across the river and carts, trucks, and men, women and children were crossing it. The mule-drawn carts staggered up the steep bank from the bridge with soldiers helping push against the spokes of the wheels. The trucks ground up and away heading out of it all and the peasants plodded along in the ankle-deep dust. But the old man sat there without moving. He was too tired to go any farther.

It was my business to cross the bridge, explore the bridgehead beyond and find out to what point the enemy had advanced. I did this and returned over the bridge. There were not so many carts now and very few people on foot, but the old man was still there.

"Where do you come from?" I asked him.

"From San Carlos," he said, and smiled.

That was his native town and so it gave him pleasure to mention it and he smiled.

"I was taking care of animals," he explained.

"Oh," I said, not quite understanding.

"Yes," he said, "I stayed, you see, taking care of animals. I was the last one to leave the town of San Carlos."

He did not look like a shepherd nor a herdsman and I looked at his black dusty clothes and his gray dusty face and his steel-rimmed spectacles and said, "What animals were they?"

"Various animals," he said, and shook his head. "I had to leave them."

I was watching the bridge and the African-looking country of the Ebro Delta and wondering how long now it would be before we would see the enemy, and listening all the while for the first noises that would signal that ever-mysterious event called contact, and the old man still sat there.

"What animals were they?" I asked.

"There were three animals altogether," he explained. "There were two goats and a cat and then there were four pairs of pigeons."

"And you had to leave them?" I asked.

"Yes. Because of the artillery. The captain told me to go because of the artillery."

1.A. Choose the correct answer from the alternatives:

(1x5=5)

(a) What could be the closest meaning for "rimmed"?

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|------------------|-------------------------------------|
| (i) edge | (ii) about a particular type of man |
| (iii) skyscraper | (iv) astonishing |

(b) The best synonym of pontoon is _____.

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|----------------------------|------------------------|
| (i) boat | (ii) down-trodden |
| (iii) extinguished quickly | (iv) abandoned forever |

(c) The word "staggered" refers to _____.

- (i) deduced extremely (ii) moved unsteadily
(iii) extremely (iv) badly

(d) The old man looked pleasant and smiling because _____.

- (i) he was satisfied with his job
(ii) he could tell the author that he came from San Carlos
(iii) he was taking care of animals
(iv) he identified the enemies who wanted to terminate the bridge

(e) Why did the old man leave his town at last?

- (i) He was totally unable to walk
(ii) He was not aware of the war situation
(iii) He had great connection with his pet animals and his native town
(iv) He was foolish

1.B. Answer the following questions:

(5x2=10)

(a) From your reading of the first paragraph of the passage, write the names of the things and beings that crossed the bridge.

(b) "But the old man sat there without moving." — Who says this? Why does s/he say this? Explain in 2 or 3 sentences.

(c) What made the old man look pleased and smiling?

(d) What did the writer of the passage think about the African-looking country of the Ebro Delta?

(e) How will you evaluate the old man's decision to leave his town?

2. Read the passage and complete the table below with the given information. 1x10=10

What/Who	Events/Occurrences	How/What	Where
An old man	(i).....		(ii).....
Cars, trucks, and (iii).....	Were crossing	(iv).....	Across the river
Soldiers	Helping push	(v).....	Up the steep bank (vi).....
The peasants	(vii).....		(viii).....
(ix).....	sat	motionless	(x).....

Or,

Read the above passage and make a flowchart showing the scene on the road. (One is done for you.)

2x5=10

1. An old man sitting by the road	→	2	→	3	→	4	→	5	→	6
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3. Summary Writing

10

Write a summary of the passage in your own words.